

Chapter 111-1: Gathering

Ning Fuyi had almost mistaken the figure in white robes when she first saw her, but then blazing flames descended from the sky and a familiar voice rang out. She immediately knew who it was, and her heart couldn't help but feel momentarily dazed as she took a few steps backward.

She had originally intended to leave immediately, but her steps mysteriously stopped as she watched the woman who had changed considerably after years of separation summon a thousand-jin¹ hammer and coldly stare at the troublemaking man.

"Hua Feiwu, this is Xiangzhou City where all the major sects have gathered. Don't go too far and disgrace Sect Leader Hua Hong of the Flying Flower Sect!" Liu Wenzhu spoke up.

Her originally gentle and soft voice had gone through countless trials and was now like clear water turned to wine—sharp and mellow.

The Hua Feiwu across from her wiped the dust that had fallen on his face, stood on his tiptoes to look at Rong Jin behind her, and sneered: "Oh my, isn't this the young master of the Liu family? Can't beat me so you called for backup? A grown man hiding behind his junior martial sister—how shameful!"

"Step aside. I'm looking for Rong Jin. It's just sparring. What kind of man is he, hiding like this?"

Seeing Rong Jin's face turn red with anger, Liu Wenzhu raised and lowered the heavy hammer in her hand, making everyone present feel their scalp tingle.

"My senior martial brother is injured and won't fight with you. Is this how disciples of the Flying Flower Sect take advantage of others' misfortune? Fine, since you want to fight, why not come at me instead? I'd like to see if you can defeat my thousand-jin hammer!" Liu Wenzhu raised her chin slightly and declared resolutely.

Hua Feiwu crossed his arms, looked back at his companion, then shook his head and turned around: "I, Hua Feiwu, am a true man who never fights with women. Winning would only make people laugh at me. Then my elder brother would scold me for bullying the weak, and you'd still win!"

"Such big talk—I think you're just scared!" Liu Wenzhu retorted.

Hearing these words, Hua Feiwu's lips suddenly curved upward. Just as he was about to raise his long sword, a sharp scream came from the collapsed courtyard, followed by angry cursing: "Which damned soul is causing trouble in the city again? Believe it or not, I'll report you to the authorities and have you all thrown out of Xiangzhou City!"

The voice was truly shrewish. Seeing someone coming, Hua Feiwu quickly exchanged glances with his companion, pointed at Liu Wenzhu and said "Wait for me," then disappeared from the spot with his companion.

Though Liu Wenzhu was angry, she didn't pursue them. Instead, she put away her thousand-jin hammer and turned to attend to Rong Jin.

However, just as she turned around, a black shadow flashed in her peripheral vision. She was immediately surprised and looked up at the now-empty wall corner.

"Senior martial brother, was there someone else here just now?" she asked with a trembling voice.

Rong Jin, having lost his cultivation, couldn't sense qi and hadn't noticed since Ning Fuyi had been standing far away. He shook his head and said softly: "I didn't notice anyone."

Liu Wenzhu was stunned for a while before lowering her head to help up Rong Jin, who was leaning against the wall.

"I thought I saw Ning Fuyi," she smiled, though there was no mirth in her eyes.

Rong Jin knew how she had spent these years. After remaining silent with her for a moment, he spoke to comfort her: "You must have been seeing things. How could Yiyi² appear here after disappearing for so many years?"

"Part of me hopes she appears, so I can know she hasn't collaborated with the demon race as the rumors say. But I also hope she never appears, because if she's caught by Penglai³ and the immortal sects, given the world's hostility toward the destroyer of the world, even if she isn't killed, she'll be imprisoned forever." Liu Wenzhu sighed heavily.

"Senior martial brother, if she really is with the demons, what should I do?" Liu Wenzhu closed her eyes tightly.

"The demon race killed my father. I swore long ago to be irreconcilable with them, but..."

Seeing this, Rong Jin interrupted her words: "Don't worry. Yiyi is kind-hearted by nature and would never do anything harmful."

"You didn't see how miserably she was persecuted by Penglai back then. If I had been the one being persecuted, I might not have been able to avoid harboring resentment and hating the immortal sects from then on."

Hearing his gentle explanation, Liu Wenzhu's worries lessened somewhat.

Just then, the woman whose courtyard wall had been destroyed poked her head out from inside the wall and continued cursing angrily. The two of them had no time to investigate further and instead bent down to apologize to her.

Ning Fuyi took advantage of this opportunity to return to the Flying Swallow Residence, standing by the window for a long time, unable to come to her senses.

She had always thought about finding a chance to explain everything to her good friends, but when the crucial moment came, she still didn't want to face it.

She didn't want to see disappointment or even hatred from those most important to her—it would be too cruel. Moreover, they were no longer in the same camp, and those immortal sects might well pursue her in the future as they had in her previous life.

If she implicated them then, it would be even more troublesome.

And now there were more important matters to attend to. Ning Fuyi quickly cleared the chaos from her mind, turned and knocked on the table edge. Outside the door, Hanyu⁴ poked out her small head.

"Hanyu, what did Yunke⁵ say?" she asked.

"Master, this is what he sent back." Hanyu took small steps into the room and handed Ning Fuyi a copied booklet.

Ning Fuyi took the booklet and opened it, her sharp lips unconsciously curving upward as she read word by word.

"They went to such great lengths just to lure me onto the island and capture me alone. I wonder what I did to offend this Heavenly Auspicious Emperor⁶ that he's so eager to kill me completely." Ning Fuyi clicked her tongue in wonder.

"Too bad for him—haste makes waste. When two armies face off, sometimes it's not about whose methods are more brilliant, but whoever loses their composure first loses."

Her voice was mysterious and ethereal. Hanyu didn't understand and blinked her two dark eyes at her.

"Now that Master knows their methods, are you still going to Six Roots Magnificent Adornment Island⁷?" Hanyu asked.

"Of course I'm going. It wouldn't be fun if I didn't." Ning Fuyi smiled sweetly as she raised her hand to burn the booklet. "Not only am I going, but I'm going to prepare a big gift for them."

Hanyu nodded in confusion, then remembered something and tapped her head: "Master, there's one more thing. That Du Baishuang⁸ said she was going out to handle some business and left after greeting us."

"That woman has too many schemes. I always feel she's not so simple. Should I secretly follow her and bring her back?" Hanyu clenched her fists.

"No need. I know where she went." Ning Fuyi touched between her brows, seeming somewhat tired.

Du Baishuang was someone who wore her schemes openly, her thoughts clear as day. But fortunately, she had no ill intentions, so Ning Fuyi simply turned a blind eye and let her be.

Her main purpose on this trip was to make Penglai lose their composure while simultaneously creating discord between Penglai and the other immortal sects.

"In a few days, you and Xique⁹ and the other demons and spirits will stay in Xiangzhou City. Under no circumstances should you go to the island. I'll arrange for Jiuying¹⁰ and people from Chuwei Hall¹¹ to accompany me. You just need to provide support from below and, if necessary, block Penglai's heavenly soldiers." Ning Fuyi instructed.

"Yes, Master." Hearing there would be fighting, Hanyu's eyes lit up with excitement as she bounced away.

Only Ning Fuyi remained in the room. She let out a long breath and leaned against the window, her gaze passing over the overlapping eaves to look toward the distant mountains at the edge of the city.

Spring was in full bloom.

Footnotes:

1. **Thousand-jin:** A jin is a traditional Chinese unit of weight, approximately 0.5 kg. A thousand-jin hammer would weigh around 500 kg, emphasizing the hammer's massive size and Liu Wenzhu's incredible strength.
2. **Yiyi:** An affectionate nickname for Ning Fuyi, showing the close relationship between the characters.
3. **Penglai:** A legendary immortal island in Chinese mythology, here referring to a powerful immortal sect.
4. **Hanyu:** Literally means "cold crow," one of Ning Fuyi's demon companions.
5. **Yunke:** Literally means "cloud guest," likely a spy or informant.
6. **Heavenly Auspicious Emperor (天瑞帝君):** A title suggesting high divine rank and authority.
7. **Six Roots Magnificent Adornment Island:** The "six roots" (六根) in Buddhism refer to the six sense organs (eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, mind). This island appears to be a significant location for the upcoming gathering.
8. **Du Baishuang:** Literally means "Du White Frost," a character with complex motivations.
9. **Xique:** Literally means "magpie," another of Ning Fuyi's demon companions.
10. **Jiuying:** Literally means "nine babies," referring to a powerful mythological creature that is one of Ning Fuyi's allies.
11. **Chuwei Hall:** Literally means "Awe Hall" or "Hall of Reverence," likely an organization under Ning Fuyi's control.